expected, not unnaturally, all the indulgence and attention which was due to her position'. Similarly, the well of Akbar's affection for his aunts and daughters was deep – Rajput notions of honour might stop Akbar from naming his brides, but they would not stop him celebrating the birth of a girl.

Its waters ran cold, however, when it came to his sons, Salim, Murad and Daniyal.

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When Father Monserrate arrived in Fatehpur, Akbar made the priest a teacher to some of the young boys in court, including the emperor's own middle son, Murad. Monserrate remembers the prince, who would have been about ten years old, as extraordinarily well behaved; indeed, 'so submissive that he sometimes did not even dare to raise his eyes to his teacher's face when he was reproving him'.

It goes against expectation, such meekness from a boy of such privilege, and certainly from a son of Akbar's – who, at that age, was running his tutors to distraction with his camels and pigeons. It was precisely because Murad was Akbar's son, however, that he was so obedient.

Akbar loved his sons. Salim he always called 'Shaikhu ji', since the boy was born by Shaikh Salim Chishti's prayers; Murad was better known as 'Pahari jiu',[58] because he was born atop a hill. The emperor took a keen interest in his children's education, too; Monserrate writes that Akbar would ask Murad to recite his new learnings to him every day. For all the affection of the nicknames and the attention that he gave them, Akbar was also often strict and impatient with his boys. 'For the King's nature was such,' remembers Monserrate, 'that, though he loved his children very dearly, he used to give them orders rather roughly . . . and he sometimes punished them with blows as well as with harsh words.'

Worse – and ironically, given his own misspent schooldays – Akbar had given the prince's new teacher leave 'to punish his pupils if they committed any offence'. Knowing the authority that Monserrate held, Murad was 'in the utmost dread of him'. When, instead of beating him, the priest spoke kindly to the boy, Murad and both his brothers 'became the closest friends of the Fathers'.